After Hours

What happens to a seller who rings when nobody is there

What this covers

A seller rings outside the shift. Nobody is at a desk. This is what happens to that call, why it was built this way, and the four ways it can go wrong -- one of which looks exactly like it working.

The shift

When	Who takes the call
Mon to Sat, 8:00 AM - 4:59 PM Pacific	the team, then the Voice AI
Mon to Sat, 5:00 PM - 7:59 AM	the live answering service
All day Sunday	the live answering service

What happens, step by step

The seller dials
Outside the shift. They do not know that, and nothing they hear tells them.

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Retell asks what time it is
Before the AI speaks a word, Retell calls the listener. This is the only moment the hour can still change the call.

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The listener decides
It works out the hour itself and answers open or closed. The AI is not asked to judge it.

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A different agent is swapped in
For a closed call only. The after-hours agent has a one-line script and no intake.

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The card is posted
AFTER HOURS -- HANDING TO THE ANSWERING SERVICE, with the caller's number and the time, so the morning shift sees the night.

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The agent speaks once and transfers
"One moment, connecting you." Then straight to the answering service on +1 408 868 5175. It asks nothing.

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The message reaches the team
The answering service takes it and passes it on in the morning.

Why it was built this way

The listener decides the hour, not the AI. Asking a language model to compare 16 against 17 in the middle of a conversation is a coin toss, and that comparison decides whether a seller reaches a person or an intake. The listener works it out and hands the agent a plain yes or no.

It is a separate agent, not a rule in the main prompt. After a fixed greeting the main agent has nothing to respond to, so it takes no turn at all until silence forces one. On test it sat for fifteen seconds and then started the intake. An agent that speaks first has no such gap.

The card says "handing to", not "handed to". It is posted when the call arrives, because that is the only moment we are certain it is an out-of-hours call -- the transfer leg looks the same as a Spanish handover or a claim. If the transfer then fails, the agent takes the seller's name and number itself and the usual callback card follows, so the team sees the truth either way.

The four ways it goes wrong

> **The one that looks like it is working**
>
> If AFTER_HOURS_AGENT_ID is not set, the card still posts saying the seller is going to the answering service -- but with no agent to swap in, the main agent takes the call and runs the full daytime intake, at eleven at night, with nobody awake to act on it. The card reads identically either way. The only signal is AFTER_HOURS_AGENT_ID_NOT_SET in the log.

- **The clock webhook does not answer.** Retell runs the call with no clock at all, no agent is swapped in and no card is posted. The seller gets the daytime intake. This is the failure that left the hour empty on every call for weeks before anyone noticed.
- **The hours are still overridden from a test.** The two hour settings exist so this path can be tested in daylight. Left set, the shift is silently wrong in whichever direction the test needed.
- **The Chat webhook is missing.** The handoff still happens and the seller still reaches the answering service -- but nobody is told it happened.

How to check it, and what we found

All three were run against the live service on 5 November 2026. Doing them again takes about five minutes.

Check	Where	Result
The transfer number	Retell, the after-hours agent, transfer_to_sas	PASS +1 408 868 5175
The agent is wired up	Cloud Run, Variables and Secrets, AFTER_HOURS_AGENT_ID	PASS matches the live agent
The hours are not overridden	ask the listener the time and compare	PASS 9 AM read as open

There are two agents in Retell with similar names. Only one is live. Check the agent id in the browser's address bar against the value in Cloud Run rather than going by the name -- the wrong one either repeats the connecting line or never says it.

What this does not do

There is no duty person. The system has two states, in-shift and answering service, and nothing between them: an evening rota where a named person takes calls until ten is not built. Every seller is answered, and none of them reach a member of the team after five.

The after-hours agent itself -- its script and the number it dials -- lives in Retell, not in the code. If calls stop reaching the answering service, start there.